that this was merely a case of myopic versus broader vision.

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Given Kiran's nature, she was not one who was going to take all these charges and insinuations lying down. She took up each charge and shot back her rejoinders with pinpoint precision. She told the media that all these ministers and bureaucrats who were finding so much fault with her work had never themselves bothered to visit the prison for personally assessing the problems in Tihar Jail. All they had ever been bothered about was to interfere in the jail functioning by seeking favours for their 'friends' who found themselves in prison. The chief minister of Delhi, Madan Lal Khurana, chose to view her rejoinders as a breach of the civil service officers' code of conduct and asked for an enquiry to be made into her mode of functioning as head of Tihar for her acts of omission and commission.

As far as the government and the administration were concerned, matters could not be left lying as they were because such a state of affairs would have meant that Kiran had ridden roughshod over them once again. Leave Tihar she must, they decided. But then the immediate problem arose: where could they send her? She had already done her stint of out-of-state postings and had been long due for a posting with the Delhi Police. Maybe that would be too close for comfort. Repeated efforts, therefore, were made to ask her to seek leave to follow her academic pursuits in furtherance of the Nehru Fellowship that had been granted to her. Her compliance would have served them in two ways. One, they could beat their chests and claim that they had effectively subdued and tamed the spirits of this 'maverick' officer and, two, as far as postings were concerned, they would not have to retrench any of their long-established officers in the Delhi Police service. Over and above all this, it would have effectively left her in 'limbo', which would have suited them very much. But they were quite mistaken if they thought she was going to be glad to grab this dangled temptation. She told them she would take her sabbatical as and only when she was ready for it and when she needed it.

The powers that be were left with no option but to transfer her from Tihar. On 5 May 1995, with almost a full year left of her tenure as IG (Prisons), Kiran was served her transfer orders. She was told to relinquish charge of Tihar and report to the commissioner of police, Delhi, to take over as additional commissioner of police (training, planning and implementation).

In 1988, under pressure from the Delhi lawyers' lobby, Kiran had been hastily transferred from being DCP (North) to commandant (CRPF) (see Chapter 9). The haste and confusion were apparent when, even before she could take up her new assignment, she was yet again transferred to the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB). The same situation was repeated at this juncture. She gave up her charge at Tihar and, even before she could take up her new assignment, she was transferred yet again to take up the duties of additional commissioner of police (planning and policy), minus training, a department, as mentioned earlier, that had never been an independent one.

Khushwant Singh summed it all up in a nutshell when he described Kiran's transfer from Tihar as 'a victory for a handful of small-minded envious people over a gutsy woman who has won laurels for herself and her country'.

In the excitement of the chase where Kiran was being pursued by the hounds of politics and bureaucracy, the hunters slipped up very drastically on two major points: First, the (Anand Narain) Mulla Committee report was a major work that recorded the abysmal depths to which the Indian prison system had sunk and recommended the ways and means of altering this hellish scenario into one where human dignity could be restored to the unfortunate people who found themselves within prison walls. The Central Government had accepted the report in principle and expressed its desire to have its recommendations incorporated in the present prison system. The Mulla Committee report,